Chewing the Cud at Santa's



Twas the night before Christmas, or the night before that,
Not a child was there stirring, not even a rat.
To be sure there were reindeer and plenty of elves,
A party at Santa's, and not just themselves,
But reporters in hordes in search of a story,
Crowded round Rudolf, with red nose of glory.

At this point, I must abandon the poem, because it goes in entirely the wrong direction. Yes, Rudolf the Reindeer had a translucent nose most remarkable, but ten times more so was Reinhold the Elf and his transparent belly. You could see everything inside of it – as disgusting a sight as it sounds – and still more amazing was the presence in the belly of a tiny cow (so said Santa) or perhaps a goat (so said Mrs. Santa) or possibly a deer (so said Rudolf, who you'd think would know). Whatever, it was alive and ate grass that grew somehow inside Reinhold. This was an intense embarrassment to Santa and all in the North Pole, and the reporters maintained a respectful silence on the matter. No one at the party would let his gaze slip below Reinhold's neck – better to omit him from conversation altogether – and no one could bring himself even to mention the ruminant in the elf.